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**United front:** The day after the cancellation of the Durand Cup match between Mohun Bagan and East Bengal due to security concerns, fans from both teams, along with supporters from other clubs like Mohammedan Sporting, gathered to protest the rape and murder of a doctor at R.G. Kar Hospital. DEBASISH BHADURI

adjoining districts. The police, struggling to contain the widespread protests, feared that the 'derby' match day, which generally sees an attendance of over 60,000, would turn the stadium into a major venue for demonstrations.

The cancellation of the season's

first major football derby between Mohun Bagan Super Giant and Emami East Bengal enraged fans. Both sets of supporters had planned to display large tifos and banners demanding justice for a crime that had deeply shocked the city. The protest calls quickly spread across

social media, drawing thousands of fans to gather at the main entrance of Salt Lake Stadium. Fans of Mohammedan Sporting Club, the third major team in the city's football scene, also joined the protest, creating a rare and powerful alliance among supporters of all three rival